

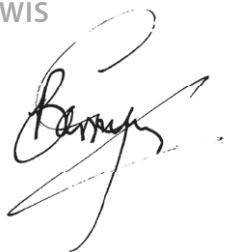
relationships between the numbers—is in danger? I sometimes think that we are drowning in numbers.

As employees, our contribution is measured by targets, statistics, workforce percentages, and adherence to budget. As consumers, we are counted and aggregated according to every act of consumption. And in a nice subtlety, most of the products that we do consume come complete with their own personal statistics—the energy in a can of beans and its “low” salt content; the story in a newspaper and its swath of statistics controlling and interpreting the world, developing each truth, simplifying each problem. Each minute of every hour, each hour of every day, we record and publish ever more readings from our collective life-support machine. That is how we seek to understand the world, but the problem is, the more figures we get, the more truth seems to slip through our fingers.

The danger is, despite all the numbers and our increasingly numerate world, math gets left behind. I’m sure that many think the ability to do the numbers is enough. Not so. Neither as individuals, nor collectively. Numbers are pinpricks in the fabric of math, blazing within. Without them we would be condemned to total darkness. With them we gain glimpses of the sparkling treasures otherwise hidden.

This book sets out to address and solve this problem. Everyone can do math.

BARRY LEWIS

A stylized, handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Barry Lewis'.

Former President, **The Mathematical Association**;
Director **Maths Year 2000**.